Before AMCAS opens

Anchor dates from the AAMC's 2027 AMCAS cycle. New dates come out each spring and usually land in the same weeks; confirm before you plan around them.

A year out (summer)

- [ ] Pick an MCAT date that leaves room for a retake
- [ ] Start an activity log: dates, hours, a contact for each
- [ ] Keep clinical and volunteer hours steady
- [ ] List possible letter writers

Fall and winter

- [ ] Apply for Fee Assistance (FAP) before paying for anything
- [ ] Study for and take the MCAT ($360 in 2027, $145 with FAP)
- [ ] Ask for letters: CV, talking points, early deadline
- [ ] Check each school's letter requirements

January to April

- [ ] Personal statement drafts (5,300 characters max)
- [ ] Activity descriptions (700 characters each)
- [ ] Choose up to 3 Most Meaningful experiences
- [ ] First school list: mission, cost, MSAR stats
- [ ] Write each school's secondary fee and deadline down

From AMCAS to acceptance

May–June: the primary

- [ ] AMCAS opens (May 5 in the 2027 cycle)
- [ ] Request every transcript the day it opens
- [ ] Submit early in the window (from May 28 in 2027)
- [ ] Pre-write secondaries: why us, challenge, diversity, gap year
- [ ] Schools start receiving applications (June 26 in 2027)

July–September: secondaries

- [ ] Turn each secondary around in about 2 weeks
- [ ] Budget for secondary fees (free to about $150 each)
- [ ] Ask about fee waivers if you have FAP
- [ ] Early Decision deadline (Aug 3 in 2027), if applying ED

September–March: interviews

- [ ] Practice traditional and MMI formats
- [ ] Test your camera, light and sound for virtual days
- [ ] Log each interview: date, people, questions
- [ ] Send thank-you notes where schools allow them

Spring: decisions

- [ ] Read the AAMC application and acceptance protocols
- [ ] Compare offers: cost, aid, fit
- [ ] Respond to every school by its deadline